



The Arnolfini Marriage by Jan van Eyck is noted for its detailed interior.

“WE READ THAT WE OUGHT TO FORGIVE OUR ENEMIES; BUT WE DO NOT READ THAT WE OUGHT TO FORGIVE OUR FRIENDS.”

Cosimo de Medici



Painting of the first Medici ruler of Florence, Cosimo.

the dauphin and were **besieging Orleans**, while the dauphin had still not managed to secure his coronation. Joan succeeded in obtaining an interview with him at Chinon, won him over, and was provided with troops and the title *chef de guerre* (“war leader”). She successfully relieved Orleans, going on to **defeat the English** twice more, and stood next to the dauphin at his coronation as Charles VII at Reims in 1429. Joan failed to take Paris, however, and the following year, she was **captured** by the Burgundians, who ransomed her to their English allies (see 1431–33).

In 1428, Le Loi, leader of Vietnamese resistance to the Chinese occupation, expelled the Chinese and founded the **Le dynasty of Dai Viet**. On admitting Chinese authority, his dynasty was recognized by the Ming.

FROM 1431 TO 1433, ZHENG HE (see 1404–07) made a seventh and final expedition, returning to the **Persian Gulf**. Despite this last trip, China’s period of exploration had come to an end with the death of **Emperor Yongle** in 1424, after which the **Ming dynasty** returned to its former isolationist policy. Surrendering the lead in exploration to Portugal and the Europeans would have profound consequences for the Chinese and for world history.

SHIP LENGTHS

72ft COLUMBUS’S SHIP
440ft ZHENG HE’S SHIP

Not all the great Renaissance painters were Italian; **Jan van Eyck** (c. 1390–1441) was Flemish. Celebrated for his mastery of realism and his perfection of oil painting, van Eyck produced some of his greatest masterpieces in the 1430s. In 1432, he and his brother Hubert completed their largest surviving work, the altarpiece of St. Bavo’s Cathedral in Ghent, Belgium. Later that year, in London, van Eyck painted the *Portrait of an Unknown Man* and the *Man with the Red Turban*; possibly a self-portrait.

In 1431, **Joan of Arc** was turned over by the English to the French ecclesiastical authorities for trial. She was found guilty of heresy, and was **burned at the stake** in Rouen.

SINCE THE 1380S, FLORENCE HAD BEEN DOMINATED by the **Albizzi** family, who extended the city’s control of Tuscany. The attempts of Visconti Milan (see 1421–22) to gain control over all of Tuscany forced Florence into a ruinously expensive war, although alliance with Venice saw **Milan defeated**. A leader of the peace party was wool merchant and banker Giovanni de Medici, possibly the richest man in Europe. After his death in 1429 and a disastrous war with Lucca in Tuscany, the Albizzi succeeded in having Giovanni’s son, Cosimo de Medici, banished from Florence in 1433, but new elections saw him returned the following year, marking the start of **Medici domination** of the city. Cosimo combined business acumen with political shrewdness, winning popular support for his policies.

All attempts by **anti-Hussite forces** under the emperor Sigismund to dislodge the Hussites and regain control of the **Czech territories** had failed (see 1416–20). The superior organization and tactics of the Hussites, first under Jan Zizka and, after his death in 1424, under **Andrew Prokops**, made them militarily powerful. In 1430, they invaded Germany and raided as far as Franconia. Negotiations with the ecumenical **Council of Basel** in 1413 led to the Compact of Prague, or *Compactata*, under which moderate Hussites (the Utraquists) agreed to go back to the Catholic Church. The extreme anti-papist Taborites rejected the

Compact, and civil war broke out between the factions, which represented different classes as well as religious ideals. In 1434, at the **Battle of Lipany**, the upper-class Utraquists vanquished the Taborites, killing Prokops.

The rising power of the Sukhothai kingdom of Thailand had increasingly threatened the **Khmer Empire** (see 1201–05) through the 14th century. Repeated **Thai raids**, particularly an incursion in 1431, may have helped

into the Atlantic had discovered the islands of **Madeira** and the **Azores**. Henry personally oversaw the colonization of these Atlantic outposts, successfully establishing them as centers of agricultural production and forward bases for **Portuguese exploration**. Henry’s next target was to round Cape Bojador on the coast of West Africa, the farthest limit of Portuguese exploration; contemporary European sailors’ lore viewed the seas beyond as a



The Windrose

The windrose mosaic at Sagres in Portugal—possibly a sundial—was commissioned by Portuguese navigator Prince Henry.

trigger the 1434 **abandonment of Angkor** (see 1146–50) and the transfer of the Khmer capital to Phnom Penh, farther south, although it is also possible that the new location offered better connections for foreign trade.

Sponsored by Prince **Henry the Navigator** (see 1416–20), Portuguese explorers pushing out

dangerous and terrifying otherworld. **Cape Bojador** was finally rounded by Gil Eannes in 1434. The experiences of his sailors on these voyages of discovery convinced Henry that the traditional barca ships in use were unsuitable, and he worked with shipwrights to design a new type of vessel, **the caravel**. This was smaller, lighter, and swifter, with a shallow draft for near-shore operations and more space for stores to allow the ships to stay at sea for longer.



May 23, 1430 Capture of Joan of Arc by the Burgundians
c. 1430 Full plate armor introduced for European knights
July 17, 1429 Coronation of dauphin as Charles VII of France
1430 Ottomans take Salonika in Greece from Venice, demonstrating their naval power

May 30, 1431 Joan of Arc burned at stake
1431 Khmer capital moved from Angkor after Thai raid. Southeast Asia
1433 Tuaregs conquer Timbuktu, Mali Empire
1432 Flemish artist Jan van Eyck completes the Adoration of the Mystic Lamb
1433 Compacts of Prague end Hussite wars
1433 Zheng He’s last voyage and subsequent isolation of China

May 30 Taborites defeated by Utraquist-Catholic alliance at **Battle of Lipany** where Procopius (b. c. 1380) is killed
June 1 Death of Wladyslaw II Jagiello (born c. 1362). Grand Duke of Lithuania and king of Poland
Cosimo de Medici (1389–1464) begins Medici dominance in Florence

Aztec Triple Alliance with Texcoco and Tiacoacan, Central America
Khmer capital moves to Phnom Penh, Southeast Asia

Portuguese explorers round Cape Bojador, West Africa
Zara Ya’qub (1399–1468) becomes king of Ethiopia